



For a cause: AIIMS students striking against reservations in educational institutes

stands in tatters. They advance numerous arguments against the policy of reservations, though some of their objections can, ironically, be read as a plea for more or better reservations. It is in this vein that one might understand the argument that reservations do not assist the poor among the upper castes and conversely only the most advantaged of the Other Backward Classes (OBCs), the so-called "creamy layer", have derived profit from reservations and thus obscured the more substantial liabilities from which the Most Backward Classes (MBCs) suffer.

Should we, some of the opponents of reservations ask, have to pay for the sins of our forefathers and remote ancestors?

B.R. Ambedkar, the principal architect of the Indian Constitution, had asked in the Constituent Assembly for reservations for 30 years, but opponents charge that the government is committed to reservations for several more generations, until such time as apparently some semblance of equality has been achieved. However, as advocates of reservations counter, there is something rather disingenuous in such claims about commitment to equality. If one should not be held accountable for the sins of one's ancestors, one should also not be able to profit by the extraordinary privileges of one's ancestors. If, for untold centuries—perhaps the same span of time is needed to reverse discrimination—only the upper castes exercised a ruthless monopoly in numerous areas of social privilege, why should their sons and daughters, in an age ostensibly bound by ideas of equality and distributive justice, derive any advantages at all?

Though opponents of reservations insistently harp on "merit", can merit be at all understood apart from the social context in which it is wrought into being and evaluated? Students who are meritorious may have vastly differential access to good schools, coaching institutions, private tutors, a safe environment, and the like.

Furthermore, the argument from the present is suspect for the obvious reason that the sins of one's ancestors may not be unrelated to the atrocities to which Dalits and the poor are still disproportionately subject to. Few upper caste families could complain of the immense disabilities that stare most Dalits in the face; almost none would be able to re-

late a tale similar to what unfolded in Khairlanji (Maharashtra) in September 2006 when Surekha and Priyanka Bhotmange were paraded naked, serially raped, and then killed alongside two male members of their family.

The most strenuous argument that has been advanced against reservations is that they would most likely be altogether unnecessary if the state had not been grossly negligent in ensuring universal education. Though there is a hue and cry over increasing "world-class" educational institutions

69%

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